region before 1824 (when the First Anglo-Burmese War began). Nevertheless, this is the case. A key part of the narrative spun by the military, ethnic extremists, Buddhist fundamentalists and the NLD is that the Rohingyas have no right to be in the country. Time and again it is written that they are ‘Bengalis’ and should live in their own country—Bangladesh. This argument is widely believed in Myanmar and is one reason why the persecution of the Rohingyas is now so much worse than that of other ethnic minorities. Those groups may have sought to overthrow the state or have a history of armed resistance stretching over forty years but, oddly, there is no doubt that they are entitled to live within the geographical boundaries of the modern state (even if the regime does seek to steal their land and exploit and monopolise its mineral wealth).

What started out primarily as a scapegoating exercise by the military regime has unfortunately been absorbed by the Myanmar public. Discriminatory thinking against the Rohingyas gradually took root more generally, and today it has become deeply engrained. After 1962, the military junta in effect[1] created a new logic whereby only Burman Buddhists could really be loyal citizens (and if not ethnically Burmese then it was even more essential that they were Buddhists). This view has caught on. The Rohingyas, visibly ‘alien’ in the colour of their skin, in their language, and most of all in their religion, have borne the brunt of this discriminatory mode of thinking, even though they have not, historically, been the only minority ethnic group in Myanmar to suffer at the hands of the military. The approach that the successive military regimes took to build a new sense of nationhood in Burma resulted in a great degree of fear of outsiders, whether they were within or outside Burma’s borders, and created a gnawing sense that other ethnic or religious groups form a constant and real threat to the viability of the country.[2]

The argument that the Rohingyas are really Bengali migrants who entered Burma during the period of British rule is widely repeated by Burmese officials in order to claim that the Rohingyas are not really Burmese.[3] Such officials, who quite unselfconsciously echo this colonial-era myth, include Ye Myint Aung, the Burmese envoy in Hong Kong, who described the Rohingyas as being as ‘ugly as ogres’ and as not sharing the ‘fair and soft’ skin of other Burmese ethnic groups.[4] Not quite the language